Assamese, or broken Assamese mixed with local expressions, which became known as ‘Nefamese’ when the NEFA was formed in the 1950s.

The only recorded presence of any Chinese, other than spies, in the area before the 1962 War was sometime between 1910 and 1912. In the late imperial era, the Chinese sent troops into Tibet. The invasion was led by General Zhao Erfeng, who earned the nickname ‘Butcher Zhao’ for his brutal suppression of the Tibetans. In 1910, his troops reached Lhasa, and according to historian John Rowland, ‘[a] pitiful force of Tibetan soldiers fought a rear-guard action while the God King [the Dalai Lama] and his entourage made good their escape to Sikkim on horseback’.[23] The Dalai Lama sought refuge in India, where he was received by the British in Kolkata.

Butcher Zhao left Tibet in 1911 to suppress a rebellion in Sichuan and was later captured and executed by rebellious republican forces. But some Chinese officials remained in Tibet until 1912, and they crossed the Himalayas into the far eastern corner of what later became the NEFA. They erected some border pillars in the far eastern south of Walong, and then withdrew.

Those markers stood there until January 1914, when a British administrator called T. O’Callaghan removed them. He also crossed the watershed into Rima on the Tibetan side, conferred with Tibetan officials there, but saw no Chinese influence even in that area.[24]

A year before O’Callaghan removed the border markers, a British expedition led by Captains Frederick Marshman Bailey and Henry Treise Morshead had been sent to survey areas west and northwest of Walong. They found the Tibetan officials alarmed at the prospect of a British takeover of the area, and even of Tibet itself.

Bailey’s account[25] of a meeting with a local Tibetan official says that,

> He asked if we were going to place officers in Mipi or in the Lohit Valley. I said that an officer was being stationed at Walong in Mishmi country. Were we then going to station officers in Tibet also? I assured him that we were not. I do not know if he believed me. He merely answered that in Tibet, their only experience of foreigners was of the Chinese and they were cruel people.

Memories of Butcher Zhao’s rampaging were still fresh in people’s minds.

Evidently, there were no Chinese administrators in the area at the time—they had left in 1912 when the occupation of Tibet ended and the Chinese